

Decision Clarity Toolkit

Editable-source review export. This is a working founder-review draft, not a customer file or available product.

FOUNDER REVIEW DRAFT — NOT FOR SALE

Decision Clarity Toolkit — Complete Draft Content v0.1

Important boundary: This toolkit supports reflection and organization. It does **not** provide legal, medical, financial, investment, tax, insurance, debt, immigration, compliance, safety, or other professional advice. For decisions in those areas, pause and consult an appropriately qualified professional.

Start Here

What this process is for

Some decisions stay difficult because they are carrying too many jobs at once: gathering facts, anticipating consequences, naming values, talking with other people, and choosing a first action. This toolkit separates those jobs. It does not make a decision “risk free,” and it does not tell you what the right answer is. It helps you create a record that is clear enough to act on, revisit, and learn from.

Before you begin

Use this toolkit only for an ordinary, non-professional personal or work-process decision. Choose a decision that is specific enough to state in one sentence. If the decision involves regulated, urgent, safety-sensitive, or high-stakes professional matters, stop and seek qualified help instead of using this as a substitute.

The six-part sequence

1. **Decision Brief:** State the situation without solving it yet.
2. **Decision Filter:** Name what matters, what is non-negotiable, and what evidence is missing.
3. **Options & Trade-off Map:** Put at least three meaningful options beside each other.
4. **Pre-mortem:** Imagine the selected direction went poorly; identify early warnings and modest responses.
5. **Captain's Brief:** Record the decision, accepted trade-off, first action, and review date.
6. **Decision Log:** Later, capture what happened and what the next 72 hours require.

Working rule: You do not need certainty to make a proportionate next move. You need enough clarity to know what you are choosing, what you are accepting, and what you will check next.

1. Decision Brief

Page 1 — Name the decision

Working title for this decision:

The situation, in plain language:

The decision I am actually making is:

I am deciding whether / how / when to _____

This decision needs a next move by: _____

Why this timing matters:

Page 2 — Define a good-enough outcome and constraints

A good-enough outcome would look like:

It does not need to look like:

Constraints I need to respect:

CONSTRAINT	WHY IT MATTERS	FLEXIBLE / NOT FLEXIBLE
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

People who are affected or need a clear update:

What belongs outside this decision for now:

2. Decision Filter

Page 1 — Criteria and non-negotiables

A criterion is something you would prefer. A non-negotiable is a condition that must be met for an option to remain viable.

CRITERION	WHY IT MATTERS	HOW I WILL RECOGNIZE IT
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

Non-negotiables:

1.

2.

3.

A preference I may need to release if it conflicts with a non-negotiable:

Page 2 — Reversibility and missing evidence

FACTOR	MORE REVERSIBLE / LESS REVERSIBLE	WHAT WOULD MAKE IT DIFFICULT TO CHANGE LATER?
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

Evidence I have:

Evidence I am missing:

The smallest appropriate way to get or test missing evidence is:

What I must not pretend to know:

3. Options & Trade-off Map

Create at least three options. “Do nothing yet,” “run a small test,” or “ask for more information” may be real options if they are named honestly.

Option A

Name: _____

What this option would involve:

BENEFITS	COSTS / EFFORT	RISKS / TENSIONS	REVERSIBILITY
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Which criteria and non-negotiables does it meet or miss?

Option B

Name: _____

What this option would involve:

BENEFITS	COSTS / EFFORT	RISKS / TENSIONS	REVERSIBILITY
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Which criteria and non-negotiables does it meet or miss?

Option C

Name: _____

What this option would involve:

BENEFITS	COSTS / EFFORT	RISKS / TENSIONS	REVERSIBILITY
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Which criteria and non-negotiables does it meet or miss?

Compare before choosing

The trade-off I am most willing to accept is:

The trade-off I am least willing to accept is:

The option that is most aligned with my non-negotiables right now is:

The option I am rejecting—and why—is:

4. Pre-mortem

Imagine that the chosen direction did not work as intended. This is not a prediction exercise. It is a way to notice assumptions early enough to respond modestly.

Working direction I am testing: _____

IF THIS WENT POORLY, WHAT MIGHT HAVE HAPPENED?	EARLIEST WARNING I COULD NOTICE	PRACTICAL MITIGATION OR CHECK
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

An assumption worth stating clearly:

A condition that would mean “pause and reconsider” is:

Who or what can provide a useful reality check, if appropriate?

5. Captain’s Brief

Use this page as the one-page record you can return to when the decision gets noisy again.

Decision

I am choosing to: _____

I am choosing it because:

Reasoning

The criteria / non-negotiables that mattered most were:

The evidence I relied on was:

Trade-off accepted

I am accepting:

I am not pretending this choice solves:

First action and review

First visible action: _____

When I will do it: _____

Review date / cue: _____

If the early warning appears, I will: _____

6. Decision Log

Complete after the first action or at the selected review date. The aim is a better record, not a self-rating.

Decision title: _____

What I did:

What happened that I expected:

What happened that I did not expect:

What I learned about the criteria, evidence, or trade-off:

My next 72-hour commitment:

What I will stop revisiting unless new evidence appears:

Fictional Worked Example A — Choosing a household information system

Fictional example. This is an everyday personal-workflow choice. It does not involve legal, medical, financial, investment, tax, insurance, debt, immigration, or other regulated advice.

Decision Brief

Mara and her partner keep important household instructions in messages, photos, and a notes app. When one person is busy, the other often cannot find the right detail. **The decision:** choose a simple shared system for recurring household information for the next 60 days.

A good-enough outcome is not “organize every document.” It is: “Either person can find the three recurring instructions we use most often within two minutes.” Their constraints are time, ease of use on their existing devices, and avoiding a system that needs constant maintenance.

Decision Filter

Criteria: easy to update, available to both people, clear enough for a guest or family member to understand, and simple to search. **Non-negotiables:** no new paid tool for the test, no move of sensitive documents into an unfamiliar platform, and no expectation that every old file will be organized immediately.

The missing evidence is whether a shared note with headings will be enough. The smallest test is to create one shared page for three recurring topics and ask each person to locate an item without help.

Options & Trade-off Map

OPTION	BENEFIT	COST / TENSION	REVERSIBILITY
A. Shared structured note	Fast, familiar, no new tool	Can become messy without headings	Highly reversible
B. Shared folder with a short index	Better for files	More setup and naming work	Reversible
C. Delay and collect examples for two weeks	Better information	Keeps the current friction in place	Highly reversible

Mara chooses **Option A** for a 60-day test because it meets every non-negotiable and creates useful evidence without overbuilding. The accepted trade-off is that it may not hold every future document. The first action is to create headings for “home routine,” “service contacts,” and “shared errands” on Tuesday evening. The review date is six weeks later.

Pre-mortem and log

If the shared note is not used, the early warning is that instructions continue to arrive in messages. The mitigation is to add only one link to the note at the end of a message, rather than asking for a new habit all at once. At the review, Mara records whether the page was

found, used, and kept current; the next 72-hour commitment is to add one missing heading only if it has been requested twice.

Fictional Worked Example B — Choosing a project check-in rhythm

Fictional example. This is a team/process choice, not employment, legal, compliance, safety, or professional advice.

Decision Brief

A small internal project team has useful weekly updates, but the meeting often becomes a status recital and decisions are made later in messages. **The decision:** choose a four-week check-in rhythm that makes blockers and next decisions visible without adding more meetings.

A good-enough outcome is: “At the end of each weekly check-in, the team knows the next owner, next action, and unresolved blocker for the active work.” Constraints: no new software, a 25-minute meeting maximum, and no additional reporting requirement.

Decision Filter

Criteria: concise, easy to prepare, makes blockers explicit, and leaves a useful written record. **Non-negotiables:** the check-in cannot become a performance scorecard; it cannot require people to report private personal information; it must stay inside the agreed 25 minutes.

The team has evidence that a simple shared agenda works; it lacks evidence about whether an asynchronous written update will make the meeting shorter. The smallest test is a shared template completed before the next two meetings.

Options & Trade-off Map

OPTION	BENEFIT	COST / TENSION	REVERSIBILITY
A. Keep the current meeting	Familiar	Decisions remain buried	Highly reversible
B. Two-question written update plus 25-minute meeting	Clear record, protected time	Requires a small preparation habit	Reversible
C. Fully asynchronous update	Less meeting time	Can leave blockers unresolved	Reversible

The team chooses **Option B** for two cycles. The accepted trade-off is ten minutes of preparation before the meeting. The Captain’s Brief records the two questions: “What moved?” and “What needs a decision or a blocker owner?” The first action is for the coordinator to put the template into the existing shared agenda before Friday.

Pre-mortem and log

If Option B fails, an early warning is that updates become long paragraphs. The mitigation is to enforce a three-line limit and take deeper discussion offline. At the first review, the team notes that blockers were clearer but one update was too detailed; the next 72-hour commitment is to rewrite the template prompt more plainly.

Production and Accessibility Notes

- [] Every worksheet begins with a descriptive heading; screen-reader navigation should follow the six-part process.
- [] Every writing field is accompanied by a visible, persistent label. Placeholder-only inputs are not sufficient.
- [] Form controls, if implemented later, follow visible page order and have programmatic labels.
- [] Print layouts retain table headings or use labelled stacked fields; no essential prompt is communicated by colour alone.
- [] Deep navy text on off-white / white paper retains print-safe contrast. Warm gold is an accent only.
- [] US Letter and A4 review must keep each worksheet title with its first prompt; a real tagged PDF / accessible form QA remains a release blocker.
- [] No example should be changed to a regulated, high-stakes, private-data, or customer-specific scenario without qualified review.